Preserving the Information Foundation of National Security

Draft proposed written testimony for Lieutenant General Paul T. Stanton, USA — not an official or delivered statement

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Chair, Ranking Member, and Members of the Committee:

OPENING

Thank you for the privilege of appearing before you on a problem that sits beneath everything else in my portfolio: whether the information our forces fight with can be trusted.

Our weapons system is the Department of War Information Network, and it has one core task: getting the right data to the right place at the right time so that our commanders make better and faster decisions than our enemies.[1] Not all the data. The right data.[2] It is hard to imagine any part of modern warfighting that does not produce, consume, move, or analyze data.[3] Every decision-support tool we field and every artificial intelligence (AI) model we train or buy rests on records: sensor readings, maintenance histories, maps, laboratory results, intelligence, and operational records.[3,4,5] If an original record is lost, its origin becomes uncertain, or an altered or generated copy is mistaken for the original, the people who depend on it can no longer tell what was observed from what was generated or changed.[6,7] That is a readiness problem, not a prediction that the internet or AI is going to fail.[8,9,10,11]

I recommend that Congress establish a focused, defense-led Strategic Information Command within the Department of Defense. Its mission would be narrow: identify defense-critical information collections, preserve recoverable originals, enable authorized and traceable use, and prove through exercises that what we preserved can be restored and evaluated when the mission needs it. It would not replace the National Archives and Records Administration (NARA), collect the civilian internet, or claim authority over civilian information. To be direct with the Committee: this command does not exist, and I am not presenting it as an approved departmental position. I am asking you to create it, and I thank the Committee for considering it.

THE RISK TO THE INFORMATION BASE

Let me describe the mechanism in plain terms.

Start with an observation: a sensor reading, a laboratory result, a maintenance write-up, a report from the field. People and machines then produce derivatives of it: summaries, translations, synthetic examples, answers from a chatbot. A later training run picks up some of those generated outputs as if they were data. If that cycle repeatedly replaces or dilutes the original observations with generated material, and if the sampling along the way drops unusual cases or carries errors forward, later models can lose coverage of parts of the source. Researchers call some forms of this degradation across generations of model training **model collapse**. It is a studied mechanism under defined conditions, not a proven fate for every model or every collection.[8,9]

Precision matters here. A fielded model does not change its learned parameters because web pages changed. Retraining on new data can change them. A deployed system can also give worse answers without any retraining, simply by retrieving poor material at run time. Deliberate poisoning of training data is a different threat: an adversary manipulating what a model learns. Attacks on retrieved context are different again. Recursive degradation needs no adversary at all.[5,8] These are different problems, and the answer to none of them is treating every generated item as hostile or every model output as a record.

The evidence is mixed and conditional, and I will not pretend otherwise. In one influential study, researchers demonstrated defects across specified recursive-training settings, including an experiment that fine-tuned a relatively small language model on a text dataset; they did not study a population of deployed frontier models. A later correction changed a theoretical condition, not the empirical results.[8,12] Other work finds that accumulating original examples can bound some error growth in studied settings, while still observing losses in diversity.[9,13] Outcomes depend on whether data are replaced, accumulated, subsampled, curated, verified, and matched to the task and model.[9,13,14] Some synthetic data improves performance on defined tasks; other tested self-training methods did not improve downstream results.[14,15] Checking generated examples before reuse helps in tested settings, but the checker's own bias can limit or reverse the gain.[16] There is no universal synthetic-data proportion or contamination threshold in this evidence, and I will not invent one.[8,12,9,13,14,15]

Nor should prevalence be confused with contamination. Pew Research Center reported that 10% of its random sample of 10,000 English-language pages from the July 2026 Common Crawl snapshot showed significant detector-based signs of AI authorship or substantial editing. That is a detector-based estimate for that sample: not a census of the internet, not a measure of how many pages were wrong, and not proof that any of those pages entered any particular model's training data. Detectors are probabilistic, and Pew's separate post-ChatGPT subset was not a random sample of the web.[10,17] A separate archive-based study found no statistically significant macro-level decline in factual accuracy under its measures; a null result is not proof of no harm.[11]

I will use the phrase “AI slop” once and then retire it; it is not a technical category, and it leads to bad rules. Synthetic examples can be useful; they can expand coverage and support controlled task training.[14] Human-authored material can be wrong. A record created before generative AI went mainstream is not therefore true, human-authored, or fit for a training purpose. Collection rules must admit valid instrument observations and algorithmically processed measurements, not just prose a person typed.[6,7] The objective is to preserve independently originated, documented records with their context, not to certify a supposedly pure pre-AI internet. Preservation is no excuse to stop collecting fresh, mission-relevant observations, and a historical record still needs quality assessment before anyone trains on it or fights with it.[7]

WHY THIS IS A READINESS ISSUE

I have testified that we align our cyber defenses to how commanders’ systems move data so that they have confidence in the data upon which they make their decisions.[1] In 2023, I put it more simply: if I am pulling in data from lots of different places, what degree of confidence do I have in a data set I did not generate?[4] Decision support is only as good as the records beneath it, the transformations applied along the way, and the evaluation used to test it. In our business, the rare case is often the one that matters: the uncommon equipment failure, the unusual environmental condition, the low-frequency logistics constraint a system must not overlook. Keeping the original record does not guarantee that a model learns from it. **Provenance**, the documented origin and history of a record, does not guarantee that the record is true. What preserved records and their provenance do is let us inspect what changed and test whether a system handles the cases that matter to its mission.[8,9,16,6,7]

Let me make that concrete with a hypothetical, not a reported incident or a claim about any particular military system. A unit moving critical supplies hits an unexpected engine fault. A decision-support tool trained on summaries of summaries produces a fluent recommendation but cannot trace the observations behind it, so it never surfaces the one inspection report that documented that failure mode. Keeping the original report, its conditions, and its revisions would not tell the mechanic what to do. It would let the mechanic and the evaluator read what the report actually says, and let us test whether the tool can find it. You do not plan an armor mission without knowing where the refuel point is, because a tank without fuel is useless.[18] Data is the same.

This is also a question of resilience. A change in an online collection does not retrain a fielded system by itself, but every new training run and every retrieval pipeline makes changing sources operationally relevant.[5] Retaining records, documenting transformations, and testing recovery are how we separate data loss from retrieval defects, training effects, and deliberate manipulation.[5,7,19] These controls manage risk; they do not eliminate it, and they cannot certify that a preserved statement is true. They complement testing and accountable human judgment; they do not replace them.

Much is said about what future superintelligent systems will do with synthetic information. The reviewed research establishes no timeline and no measured outcome for such systems, and I will not speculate for you.[8,9,16] Whatever those systems become, they will not remove the requirement to actually understand what our data says; you still have to know how to read the map before you do land navigation, even if the GPS gets you there faster.[20] I do not need the forecast. The records we depend on today for maintenance, logistics, planning, and the evaluation of tools we are already fielding justify this mission on present readiness grounds alone.[1]

A FOCUSED STRATEGIC INFORMATION COMMAND

I have said before that attempting to defend everything effectively defends nothing.[21] The same discipline applies to preservation. I am not asking for a new global unified combatant command or for anyone to own all information. I am asking for a focused military Strategic Information Command within the Department of Defense with a single purpose: operational accountability for the preservation and assurance of defense-critical information. Creating an organization proves nothing by itself. The Secretary of Defense should define its internal reporting relationships and resolve overlaps in an implementation plan before it grows. It complements the defense and civilian organizations already in this space; it does not displace them.[7,19,22,23] I propose four duties.

First, **identify and prioritize**. The command should find existing defense-critical information collections and name their custodians, ranking them by mission dependency, uniqueness, provenance quality, and risk of loss. Examples include original government and scientific observations, authoritative technical and historical records, and lawfully held defense mission datasets. Every prioritized collection gets a named custodian, a stated operational purpose, and documented access and use conditions. Think in context.[18] Indiscriminate capture of the civilian internet is not the mission.

Second, **preserve recoverable originals**. That means versioned, access-controlled preservation copies in geographically separated locations; fixity records, meaning checks of whether the stored bytes have changed; chain-of-custody metadata; and restoration that is actually tested. Originals stay distinguishable from cleaned, annotated, translated, summarized, or synthetic derivatives, and documented transformations show what was altered and by whom when that is known. Unknown origin stays unknown. No office gets to stamp material “untainted” after the fact when its provenance is missing. All of this operates within lawful retention schedules and security requirements, not as an exception to them.[6,7,19]

Third, **enable authorized, traceable use**. The command should maintain records of origin, transformation, rights, and access restrictions, and keep observed material separate from generated material. Signatures, watermarks, detectors, and checksums each answer a narrow question; none

alone tells you that a claim is true or that a dataset is fit for a particular purpose.[6,24,25] The command should use the Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) for infrastructure and secure operations and coordinate data and AI evaluation with the Chief Digital and Artificial Intelligence Office (CDAO).[3,22] It should work with Department records officials, component custodians, NARA, and other civilian custodians while respecting their existing responsibilities.[7,19,23] Civilian archives, universities, and research institutions participate only through lawful agreements under applicable rights and access conditions. There is no general content-policing power here, no compulsory civilian collection authority, and no control over civilian archives. Those boundaries are the proposal, not details to be settled after collection begins.

Fourth, **demonstrate readiness**. We require our people to qualify on their weapons systems and to go back to the range periodically to validate that they can actually execute the task.[3,26] Hold the data to the same standard. The command should run independent restoration exercises and task-relevant evaluations of data and models, including the uncommon but consequential cases, with held-out evaluation material protected from training leakage so results mean something. It should report provenance coverage for prioritized collections, restoration outcomes, task-specific error and diversity changes, unresolved custody or access issues, and lifecycle costs, not bytes collected. These are proposed measures, not claimed performance. A passed checksum proves one narrow property; whether records and systems are suitable for their intended tasks is a separate test.[6,7,19]

CONGRESSIONAL DIRECTION AND ACCOUNTABILITY

I ask the Committee for three things.

First, authorize the mission. Establish this narrow preservation-and-assurance command with named accountability, defined boundaries, and safeguards for civil liberties and civilian control. Do not assume that existing general organizational law already authorizes it; I am not making that claim. On nomenclature: in my own testimony I refer to the Department of War,[1] but the official 2024 edition of 10 U.S.C. §111(a) names the Department of Defense, and Executive Order 14347 makes Department of War a secondary title while leaving controlling statutory references in place. Unless Congress changes the law, the authorizing language should use the statutory name.[27,28]

Second, require a costed, phased implementation plan before expansion. It should use capabilities we already have, identify duplication, and describe the command's relationships with DISA, CDAO, the Department Chief Information Officer, component records officials, NARA, and other custodians, including what stays with each and how retention, security, restoration, and evaluation will be funded.[3,7,19,22,23] It should compare establishing the command with strengthening existing offices and

explain what accountability it adds. I will not give you a dollar figure, a staffing number, or a savings estimate without a reviewed basis. A new headquarters is no substitute for proving that it can do the mission better without avoidable duplication.

Third, require annual reporting and independent oversight by the Government Accountability Office or the Inspector General, with explicit safeguards for privacy, civil liberties, copyright, classification, and lawful access. Reports should separate completed, independently checked results from planned work, and disclose unresolved custody and access gaps, restoration outcomes, task-specific evaluation findings, duplication identified, and lifecycle costs. Oversight should ask whether the command stayed inside its authorized mission, followed access controls and retention rules, and respected civilian custodians and private rights. Existing archival standards and institutional responsibilities are the foundation; the case for a focused military command is a judgment about accountable defense readiness, not a scientific finding that every other organizational model is inferior.[7,19,29,22,23]

These limits are not caveats; they are how the mission stays credible. The command preserves only what defense mission needs and lawful access justify, gets no mandate to monitor or judge civilian speech, and leaves archival custody and records responsibilities where they belong while making defense-critical material recoverable and its transformations traceable. It uses controls proportionate to risk and does not pretend that one label, one detector, or one provenance tool classifies all information reliably. If the mission, partners, or data uses change, Congress should hear about it and retain oversight.

CLOSING

The decision in front of the Committee is narrow. It is not whether older data is trustworthy or whether synthetic data is dangerous; the evidence supports neither as a blanket claim.[14,6,7] It is whether to establish an accountable, bounded defense mission that preserves recoverable information and proves, on a schedule, that it can still be used. Preserving original records will not by itself produce good models or sound decisions. Losing the ability to inspect and recover them would narrow our options.[6,7,19] Our mission never rests,[3] and the records it depends on deserve the same standard of accountability. I recommend that Congress establish the Strategic Information Command with clear civilian boundaries, cost discipline, and independent evaluation. Thank you. I look forward to your questions.

ENDNOTES

Source identifiers in brackets refer to the research package catalog (source-catalog.jsonl). "Local record" paths are relative to the package directory.

1. **[S003]** U.S. Senate Committee on Armed Services, *Enterprise Security and Information Technology Operations of Department of Defense Networks and Systems*, S. Hrg. 119–495, hearing March 24, 2026; GPO publication 2026. Stanton oral remarks PDF pp. 12–14 ("our weapons system, the Department of War Information Network," right data/better and faster decisions, p. 12; "confidence in the data upon which they make their decisions," p. 13) and his prepared statement pp. 14–17 ("one core task," p. 14). Only Stanton's identified remarks are used; co-witness testimony precedes his. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S003.md`.
2. **[S009]** Nuray Taylor, "DISA's Stanton: Network Architectures Should Work Like Legos," AFCEA International / SIGNAL Media, August 20, 2026, reporting on the TechNet Augusta 2026 closing keynote; attributed remark "The right data to the right place at the right time. Not all the data." Secondary reporting with short attributed quotations, not a transcript. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S009.md`.
3. **[S001]** Lieutenant General Paul T. Stanton, "Statement by Lieutenant General Paul T. Stanton, USA, Commander, Joint Force Headquarters – Department of Defense Information Network, Director, Defense Information Systems Agency, Before the Senate Armed Services Subcommittee on Cybersecurity," May 21, 2025, prepared statement, PDF pp. 2–5 ("Our mission never rests," data in modern warfighting, and distinct JFHQ-DoDIN/DISA roles, p. 2; workforce "qualified on their respective cybersecurity weapon system," p. 3). Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S001.md`.
4. **[S040]** Jaspreet Gill, "Army cyber officials want to harness AI, but not over-hype," Breaking Defense, August 21, 2023, reporting an August 17, 2023 TechNet Augusta media briefing by then-Maj. Gen. Stanton, Commander, Cyber Center of Excellence; attributed remarks that AI "is predicated on the aggregation of a lot of data" and the question of the "degree of confidence" in a data set "that I didn't generate." Secondary reporting; it records a question about dataset confidence, not a position on recursive training or on this proposal. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S040.md`.
5. **[R015]** National Institute of Standards and Technology, *Adversarial Machine Learning: A Taxonomy and Terminology of Attacks and Mitigations*, NIST AI 100-2e2025, March 24, 2025, §3.1.1, printed pp. 36–39; §§2.3 and 3.2.1 on poisoning; §3.4 on indirect prompt injection. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R015.md`.
6. **[R014]** National Institute of Standards and Technology, *Reducing Risks Posed by Synthetic Content: An Overview of Technical Approaches to Digital Content Transparency*, NIST AI 100-4, November 2024, Executive Summary and §3.1. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R014.md`.
7. **[R016]** National Archives and Records Administration, *Digital Preservation Strategy 2022–2026*, Strategies 4–6 and Activities 1–4. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R016.md`.
8. **[R001]** Ilia Shumailov et al., "AI models collapse when trained on recursively generated data," *Nature* 631, published July 24, 2024, journal pp. 755–759, "What is model collapse?" and OPT-125m/WikiText-2 language-model experiment pp. 757–758. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R001.md`.
9. **[R003]** Matthias Gerstgrasser et al., "Is Model Collapse Inevitable? Breaking the Curse of Recursion by Accumulating Real and Synthetic Data," arXiv version 2, April 29, 2024, §§2.1–2.3 and 3, including §2.3/Fig. 6. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R003.md`.
10. **[R011]** Pew Research Center, "How Much of the Internet Is Written With AI?," August 20, 2026, opening visualization and July 2026 estimate. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R011.md`.
11. **[R013]** Jonas Dolezal et al., "The Impact of AI-Generated Text on the Internet," arXiv v1, April 14, 2026, Results/Hypothesis 2, §§3.1–3.4 and Appendices A/D. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R013.md`.

12. **[R002]** *Nature*, "Author Correction: AI models collapse when trained on recursively generated data," March 21, 2025, p. E6. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R002.md`.

13. **[R040]** Joshua Kazdan et al., "Collapse or Thrive: Perils and Promises of Synthetic Data in a Self-Generating World," *Proceedings of Machine Learning Research* 267, October 6, 2025, §§2–4/Fig. 4. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R040.md`.

14. **[R008]** Feiyang Kang et al., "Demystifying Synthetic Data in LLM Pre-training: A Systematic Study of Scaling Laws, Benefits, and Pitfalls," EMNLP 2025, §§4–6. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R008.md`.

15. **[R056]** Yusuke Nakamura et al., "Demystifying Mixed Outcomes of Self-Training: Pre-training Analyses on Non-Toy LLMs," *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EACL 2026*, March 2026, §§2–4 and limitations. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R056.md`.

16. **[R009]** Bingji Yi et al., "Escaping Model Collapse via Synthetic Data Verification: Near-Term Improvements and Long-Term Convergence," ICLR 2026 main-conference paper, published April 20, 2026, §§2–6, particularly verifier bias in §§3–4 and reference-based summarization in §5.3. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R009.md`.

17. **[R012]** Pew Research Center, "Methodology: How Much of the Internet Is Written With AI?," August 20, 2026, sampling and detector-method sections. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R012.md`.

18. **[S051]** Marco A. Villasana Jr., DISA Public Affairs, "DISA director urges cyber professionals to embrace warfighting mindset at HammerCon 2025," Defense Information Systems Agency, published July 1, 2025; attributed remarks "Don't randomly chase incidents. Don't chase events. Think in context." and the armor refuel-point analogy for data. Official reporting, not a speech transcript. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S051.md`.

19. **[R017]** National Archives and Records Administration, "About the Digital Preservation Program," program overview, undated page (catalog metadata: first published September 4, 2019; modified March 20, 2026). Public source; local record: `sources/research/R017.md`.

20. **[S065]** Tim D. Godbee, DISA Public Affairs, "DISA director at HammerCon 2026: Cyber forces must master fundamentals to maneuver at speed of SI," Defense Information Systems Agency, published October 5, 2026, reporting the September 24, 2026 Commander's Panel; attributed remarks "We can't lose a focus on the foundation" and "You still have to know how to read the map before you can do land navigation, even if the GPS is going to help you get there faster." Official reporting, not a transcript. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S065.md`.

21. **[S028]** Jason Miller, "Cyber Command's order creates 'inflection point' for DoDIN," Federal News Network, published January 23, 2025, reporting a January 13, 2025 press briefing; attributed remark "I have said in the past that attempting to defend everything effectively defends nothing." Secondary reporting with short attributed quotations. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S028.md`.

22. **[R025]** Chief Digital and Artificial Intelligence Office, Department of Defense, "Mission and Priorities," public mission page, accessed October 7, 2026. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R025.md`.

23. **[R046]** U.S. Department of Defense, *Department of Defense Records Strategy*, May 2023, §§3.1 and 4.2. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R046.md`.

24. **[R035]** Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity, *C2PA and Content Credentials Explainer*, version 2.2, released December 11, 2025, §§2, 7.1.2, and 7.2. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R035.md`.

25. **[R036]** Hari Iyer et al., *2024 NIST GenAI (Pilot Study): Text-to-Text Evaluation Overview and Results*, NIST AI 700-1, June 25, 2025, §§7.1, 8.2–8.4, 9.2. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R036.md`.

26. **[S027]** Lisbeth Perez, "Stanton Calls for Weapon-System Mindset to Improve Cyber Readiness," MeriTalk, September 10, 2026, reporting on the Billington CyberSecurity Summit; attributed remark on being qualified on your task and periodically going "back to the range" to validate execution. Secondary reporting, not an audio-verified transcript. Public source; local record: `sources/stanton/S027.md`.

27. **[R019]** Executive Order 14347, "Restoring the United States Department of War," September 5, 2025, §2. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R019.md`.

28. **[R021]** United States Code, 10 U.S.C. §111(a), 2024 edition, subsection (a). Public source; local record: `sources/research/R021.md`.

29. **[R018]** U.S. Government Accountability Office, *Artificial Intelligence: DOD Should Improve Strategies, Inventory Process, and Collaboration Guidance*, GAO-22-105834, March 30, 2022; live recommendations page at the cutoff lists recommendations 1–6 as Closed–Implemented and recommendation 7 as Open, with an August 2026 update estimating completion by April 2027. Public source; local record: `sources/research/R018.md`.